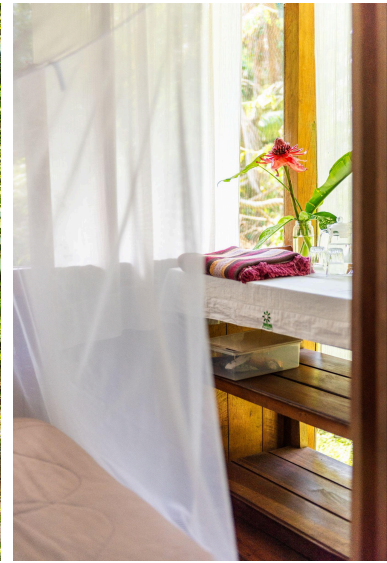
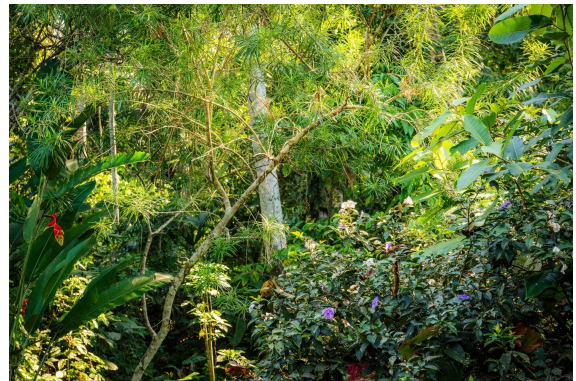




Soon, we learned to live the way the rainforest creatures do—setting out at dawn, then resting through the worst of the midday heat in a hammock, dozing like a lazy jaguar. My mom told me the environment reminded her of her own childhood: hot summer nights with no appliances to keep cool, when neighbors carried benches outside to chat under the stars, waving hand fans until the air finally cooled enough for sleep. After hearing that, even the heavy heat around us felt gentler somehow.



Our first lunch was unforgettable. Our guide handed each of us a steaming parcel wrapped in palm leaves. Inside were rice, chicken, and sweet peppers—simple and delicious, evoking memories of the Zongzi from my hometown. In that one bite, the shared wisdom of distant continents seemed to meet.

